

History Study Notes: The French Revolution

The French Revolution was a period of radical political and social change in France that began in 1789 and ended in 1799.

Causes of the Revolution

Key causes included social inequality (the Three Estates system), severe financial crisis due to war debts, and high taxes on the Third Estate (peasants and bourgeoisie) while the First and Second Estates (clergy and nobility) enjoyed tax exemptions.

The Storming of the Bastille

On **July 14, 1789**, an armed mob of Parisian revolutionaries stormed the **Bastille**, a medieval fortress and political prison representing royal tyranny. This event marked the beginning of the popular uprising.

The Reign of Terror

Between 1793 and 1794, the Committee of Public Safety, led by **Maximilien Robespierre**, initiated the **Reign of Terror**. During this phase, thousands of suspected counter-revolutionaries were executed using the guillotine.